

Natural Icecream

Natural Ice Cream was founded in 1984 by the late Shri Raghunandan S. Kamath in Mumbai. Kamath's entrepreneurial journey was shaped by years of hands-on experience and deep knowledge of fruits. Growing up in a fruit-trading family in Mangalore, he developed a strong understanding of produce quality, seasonality, and natural flavors from an early age. Later, while working in his brother's eatery business where ice cream was served, he gained practical exposure to the dessert trade and customer preferences.

The blend of fruit expertise and hands-on experience in the ice-cream trade inspired **Raghunandan S. Kamath** to build a brand centered on real fruit, simple ingredients, and authentic taste. This philosophy led to the creation of **Natural Ice Cream**, which stood out in a market largely driven by artificial flavors and synthetic additives. He strongly believed in the idea: *"If I want to sell ice cream, I should invest in trees,"* highlighting his commitment to sourcing genuine fruit ingredients rather than relying on artificial substitutes.

Through Naturals, he addressed several key gaps he observed in the market:

- **Quality over shortcuts** – Promoting dairy-based ice cream instead of products made with vegetable fats.
- **Natural flavors** – Using real fruits rather than artificial flavoring agents.
- **No preservatives** – Keeping recipes simple and fresh.
- **Better hygiene standards** – Maintaining cleanliness and product integrity.
- **Fair value for customers** – Offering premium, fruit-based ice cream at reasonable prices.

Brand launching idea

In its initial phase, **Natural Ice Cream** was not introduced as a premium, standalone ice-cream outlet. Instead, they adopted a practical and customer centric approach. He began with a small eatery where pav bhaji was the primary dish, and ice cream was offered as an add-on dessert. This model helped him observe consumer preferences, build steady footfall, and gradually generate interest in his fruit-based ice creams.

As customer demand for the dessert grew stronger than for the main course, the focus slowly shifted toward ice cream. Over time, the modest eatery evolved into a dedicated ice-cream parlour in **Juhu**, which went on to become a landmark location and played a key role in shaping Naturals' identity as a specialty fruit ice-cream brand.

Unique Feature

Natural Ice Cream stands out in the market because of its signature three ingredient philosophy. Their ice creams are primarily made using **milk, sugar, and real fruit**, keeping

recipes simple and close to nature. Staying true to this approach, Naturals does **not use artificial flavors, synthetic colors, preservatives, or chemical additives** in its fruit-based ice creams. The brand is extremely selective about ingredient quality, carefully sourcing fresh, seasonal fruits to ensure authentic taste.

Another distinctive feature of Naturals ice cream is its **low overrun**, meaning less air is whipped into the mixture. This results in a **denser, richer, and creamier texture**, which customers often associate with the brand's premium and natural feel.

The true magic of **Natural Ice Cream** lies in its fruits. The brand is known for sourcing produce from regions famous for growing the best-quality varieties, ensuring authentic taste and natural flavor in every scoop.

- **Chikoo (Sapota)** – sourced from **Gholvad**, a region well known for premium chikoo orchards
- **Pineapples** – procured from farms in **South India**, where the fruit grows in ideal tropical conditions
- **Jackfruit** – sourced from the **Konkan** region and parts of **Andhra Pradesh**
- **Lychees** – brought from **Muzaffarpur**, one of India's most famous lychee-growing regions
- **Tender Coconuts** – sourced from **Kerala** and **Karnataka**
- **Sitaphal (Custard Apple)** – procured from **Saswad**, known for its high-quality produce
- **Mangoes (especially Alphonso)** – sourced from **Ratnagiri**, famous for its rich, aromatic mangoes
- **Strawberries** – grown in **Mahabaleshwar**, India's strawberry capital
- **Pistachios** – imported from **Iran**, known globally for premium pistachios
- **Kiwis** – imported from **New Zealand**, one of the world's leading kiwi producers

This careful and region-specific sourcing strategy allows Naturals to maintain its signature freshness, authenticity, and fruit-forward flavor profile.

Why Natural's ice cream is never boring?

Natural Ice Cream offers its flavors in thoughtfully designed categories that revolve around seasonality, availability of fresh produce, and customer excitement:

- **All-Year-Round Classics**
These are the brand's signature and most-loved flavors that remain available throughout the year. They typically include staples like Tender Coconut, Sitaphal, Chocolate, and other consistent favorites that customers can rely on anytime.
- **Seasonal Specials**
These flavors celebrate the best fruits of a particular season. Naturals introduces limited-time varieties based on peak harvests — for example, Alphonso Mango during summer or Strawberry during winter. This ensures maximum freshness, flavor intensity,

and authenticity.

- **Festive Specials**

Certain flavors are launched around Indian festivals and cultural celebrations. These may draw inspiration from traditional sweets, festive ingredients, or nostalgic seasonal tastes, adding an emotional and cultural connection to the product.

- **Friday Fun Flavors**

A unique concept where new or experimental flavors are introduced on Fridays. These limited releases create excitement, encourage repeat visits, and allow customers to try innovative combinations.

- **Berry Festival (Special Feature)**

Apart from regular categories, Naturals also hosts a dedicated **Berry Festival**, where a variety of berry-based flavors are launched for a short duration. This showcases rare and premium berries, offering customers a special tasting experience not commonly available in standard menus.

This structured flavor strategy helps Naturals maintain freshness, exclusivity, and strong customer engagement throughout the year.

Challenges faced

1. In the early days of **Natural Ice Cream**, production was a major challenge due to limited access to specialized ice-cream-making equipment. Instead of relying on expensive imported machinery, **Raghunandan S. Kamath** took an innovative approach. He improvised and helped develop in-house machines and tools that made it easier to process fruits, remove seeds and pulp efficiently, and produce ice cream in larger quantities. These practical innovations allowed Naturals to scale production while staying true to its core promise of using real fruits and maintaining freshness without industrial shortcuts.
2. **Rising Competition After Economic Liberalization**
After India's economic liberalization in the 1990s, the ice-cream market saw the entry and expansion of large national and international brands such as **Baskin-Robbins**, **Kwality Wall's**, and **Amul**. These companies had strong financial backing, widespread distribution networks, attractive packaging, and mass production capabilities. Their products often had longer shelf lives, relied on standardized industrial processes, and were supported by large-scale marketing.

Naturals, however, chose not to compete on mass production, heavy advertising, or long shelf-life products. Instead, it stayed committed to its core philosophy — small-batch production, real fruit ingredients, seasonal flavors, and freshness. While this meant

slower expansion and operational challenges, it helped the brand maintain a unique identity and strong customer loyalty. They expanded without diluting the flavours.

Natural's journey so far

- **1984** – The journey began with a small eatery in **Juhu**, started by **Raghunandan S. Kamath** with a team of just six staff members.
- **1994** – Expansion within Mumbai began with new outlets in **Malad, Borivali, Bandra, Lokhandwala**, and **Vile Parle**.
- **2000** – Naturals opened its **first outlet outside Mumbai** in **Pune**, marking the start of its intercity expansion.
- **2009** – Further growth led to outlets in **Ahmedabad, Goa**, and **Hyderabad**.
- **2010** – The brand entered southern and northern markets with stores in **Bengaluru** and **Jaipur**.
- **2012** – The original Juhu outlet gained national recognition, becoming one of India's highest-revenue exclusive ice-cream parlours, reportedly crossing ₹5 crore in annual sales.
- **2014** – Naturals expanded into the capital city with outlets in **Delhi**.
- **2015** – The **Connaught Place** outlet in **Delhi** set a new benchmark, reportedly achieving around ₹8.5 crore in annual sales.
- **2018** – The brand continued its eastern expansion by opening outlets in **Kolkata**.

This steady, city-by-city expansion reflects Naturals' strategy of controlled growth while preserving quality, freshness, and its fruit-first philosophy.

Achievements

- **India's Leading Artisan-Style Ice Cream Brand**
Naturals is widely recognized as one of India's largest traditional, fruit-based ice cream brands, producing **around 25 tons of ice cream per day**. Operations reportedly involve the daily use of **over 32,000 litres of milk** and the sale of **thousands of Tender Coconut ice creams each day**, highlighting the scale of demand for its natural offerings.
- **Recognition by Industry Bodies**
Naturals has been featured among notable **homegrown Indian brands** in industry reports such as those by **KPMG**, acknowledging its strong brand identity and unique business model.
- **Media & Business Honors**
The brand and its founder, **Raghunandan S. Kamath**, have received recognition from leading business publications like **The Economic Times**, celebrating their contribution to Indian entrepreneurship.

- Celebrity Appreciation**
 Legendary cricketer **Viv Richards** is known to have publicly appreciated and supported the brand, reflecting its wide popularity and goodwill.
- No Traditional Advertising Model**
 One of Naturals' most remarkable achievements is building a powerful national brand **without heavy spending on advertising**. Its growth has largely been driven by **word-of-mouth publicity**, strong customer loyalty, and consistent product quality.
- Pioneer of the Fruit-First Ice Cream Concept in India**
 Naturals helped popularize the concept of **real fruit ice cream** at a time when artificial flavors dominated the market, influencing consumer expectations and industry standards.
- Strong Retail Presence with Premium Positioning**
 Several Naturals outlets, including its flagship stores, have achieved **record-breaking retail sales** for exclusive ice-cream parlours, demonstrating both brand strength and customer trust.

Business Lessons

Scale Right, Not Fast

Instead of aggressive expansion, Naturals focused on controlled growth. Each outlet was opened only when supply chains, fruit sourcing, and quality consistency could be maintained. This ensured the brand never outgrew its ability to deliver freshness.

Quality Over Quantity

The company chose real fruit, milk-based recipes, and small-batch production over mass manufacturing and long shelf-life products. By prioritizing taste and authenticity rather than volume, Naturals built strong customer trust and loyalty.

Create Urgency with Intention

Through seasonal flavors, limited-time fruit availability, and special editions like Friday Fun Flavors, Naturals naturally created scarcity. Customers knew certain flavors wouldn't be available year-round, which encouraged repeat visits and impulse purchases.